

Shadows of Titan

amplified me when she healed me.” He flexed his fingers, watching the energy shimmer between them.

“I haven’t even used my energy yet, but I know I’ve Tiered up. If she could do this for all of us? In a fight we would stand a chance. A real one.”

Lyra chewed her lip. “What happens if she turns on us?”

“What happens if *we* turn on us?” Vexal asked back. “This isn’t just winning anymore. I’m not going to lie to you. We are in survival mode. He wants her and if he gets her, we die. The AAN will find out in a matter of time and she will be forced to pick a side. If she sides with us, we are safe and have everything we ever dreamed. If she sides with them, then it's over. I didn’t know what kind of power she had or I would have never let her go into the Apex Corps. But it’s too late to do anything about that. So it is do or die.” He looked at them both. “There are only two threats alive that could hope to match her Tier. One, in his current state, is no match unless he synergised with her or forcibly drained her. I don’t think he could get to her forcibly, but he would try to synergise with her if he did. The other... is Commander Thal Voxx.”

The name settled like lead in the room.

Korric broke the silence first. “Then we support her.”

Vexal nodded. “Exactly. And, alone, I will tell her exactly what we are dealing with when I have more info. Maybe what she has done for me she can do for you. That would give us at least a fighting chance individually if we are smart. Which leads me to this.” He stood, rolling his shoulder, the resonance of his energy flickering along his spine as he stepped toward the centre of the room.

“We synergise. Then we go into every corner of the Undercity. We need to recruit an army.”

Shadows of Titan

Lyra raised an eyebrow. “An army?”

Vexal felt the gleam in his eye. He nodded. “Anybody loyal. We have been lying low for too long. The Big O will be our headquarters. A war is coming whether we like it or not. I stand to be prepared. And to come out on top. What about you?”

Korric stood and nodded; Lyra followed suit. Vexal placed an arm around each of their shoulders.

“To the future,” he said.

“To the future,” Korric said assuredly.

“To the future,” Lyra followed up, her face at ease, eagerness in her eyes.

Chapter 15

The air snapped shut behind her, leaving nothing but silence and sterility in its wake. Nyx stood motionless in the centre of her dorm room. The quiet was almost buzzing in her ears, it felt something like static. The room was so perfect, a faceless cell lined with titanium and soft blue, like the architects had designed it to choke out anything that didn't fit. Her boots didn't even echo on the floor.

She pushed down the rising panic as the uniform slid from her shoulders with a low whisper and pooled at her feet. Her skin prickled with the memory of fire and screams, rot and silver light bursting from her hands. Her fingers trembled and she sat down slowly on the edge of the bed, her limbs stiff, her mind spinning. She stared blankly ahead, trying to find a thought to comfort herself. *Vexal*. He'd held her after she had saved him, after she had almost killed him.

Shadows of Titan

She shook her head, trying to shake the images of him lying on her bed. All mangled and bloody, he had been barely breathing. She hadn't known if she could fix him, but she had tried her best.

And then... he sent her away.

It stung, even though he was right. She had to be here. But why did it hurt so much? Her voice escaped her in a whisper. "Am I just... a thing?"

The word *siphon* echoed in her skull. They wanted to use her, drain her, burn her until there was nothing left. Maybe that's what happened the last time? *Maybe that's why I died.*

She curled her fingers against her arms, her sharp nails digging into her skin. Her energy danced and flickered lightly under the surface. She lay down, just enough for the bed to catch her, and stared at the ceiling.

Suddenly, a scream of red light and shrieking metal rattled through the building. She flinched and sat up slowly, reaching for her uniform. Her body ached, but not because she needed energy yet; it was something else. She shook off the thought and pulled her uniform back on.

The hallway outside was chaotic; AAN officers and cadets alike ran to get into formation, boots striking the polished floors in unison. Others shouted into comms, faces tight with urgency. She blended into the river of bodies, moving with the surge; it seemed like her absence hadn't been noticed.

They gathered in the main briefing hall, all taking formation in a blur of metal, gauntlets and breathing gear being strapped on with cold efficiency.

Shadows of Titan

Commander Voxx stood at the front, his winged silhouette sharp against the projection screen. Beside him, Dr. Rhea Vaelith stood composed, her emerald-green skin a sharp contrast to her white uniform, her expression stern.

Commander Voxx's voice cut through the room. "Attention. Environmental collapse at Baseline Miridan Fringe. Near the Obscura Noctis Belt. Structural destabilisation, toxic surge, and civilians trapped. This is a save-and-recover mission. You move in squads. Don't die out there."

Dr. Vaelith's voice followed, calm and calculated. "Air quality is highly unstable; there are heat pockets and tremor shifts still active. Your gear won't last forever, so move fast and extract who you can."

They were dismissed with the weight of urgency hanging over them. Darius appeared beside her with a sceptical look on his face. "You good?" he asked, his voice low.

She nodded once. "Fine."

She could tell he didn't buy it, but he didn't press.

When the Apex Corps transport brigade reached the edge of the Obscura, the district looked more like a graveyard than anything else. Ruins leaned into the sky like broken bones and the toxic mist moved in pulses like thick oil and twice as corrosive. The sky above flickered with chemical burns, casting everything in a sickly greenish-yellow haze. Nyx's protective cloak fluttered behind her as she warped ahead of the others, the space around her shimmering, pushing the poisonous air away from her skin.

"Nyx!" Darius called out behind her.

Shadows of Titan

She'd already found them, survivors. A handful of ash-covered civilians cowering beneath a collapsed bridge. Her hand twisted, the debris lifting like it was weightless. A small child crawled to her and clutched her leg.

She slowed, her voice soft. "You're safe now. I've got you." She warped the survivors to the extraction point and moved on quickly.

She did it again and again, Darius following behind, helping the survivors group together so that warping them wasn't so disorienting. The effort became mechanical after a few hours. The damage seemed to last forever. She stopped feeling her feet; her back was on fire. But she forced herself to continue, her mind detached from the screams echoing throughout the wasteland.

By the time the mission was over, the sun had long dipped below the Titan skyline. But all the civilian bodies had been recovered. Not all alive.

Nyx staggered on the way back to the transport, her fingertips burning, her breathing shallow and uneven. Darius caught her arm just before she fell.

"Do you need to go to medical?" he asked sternly, his molten eyes steaming slightly at the corners from sweat mixing with heat.

"I'm just tired," she huffed.

The ride back was almost silent. No one had the energy to do much. She immediately escaped to her dorm when they landed. She didn't have the energy to pretend to eat. As soon as the door shut, she leaned against it hard. Her hands shook terribly as she unclipped her uniform and started toward the bed. No change of clothes, no shower. Just the growing ache behind her ribs where her energy should've been. She fell hard at the foot of her bed. Not bearing to lie down on the overly clean sheets, her eyes closed right where she was.

Shadows of Titan

Her final thoughts were full of worry. *How long? Until I fall apart completely.*

The next morning arrived faster than she wanted. The pale light cut across the room, filtering through the blue glass. Nyx hadn't moved; her body was leaden, her eyes burned, and a headache pounded behind her temples.

A knock rang out strongly. Then again, almost a bang. "Nyx!" Darius's voice rang out. "Nyx, open this door, now!" The voice slammed through her head like a hammer. "You missed roll call, breakfast, and a check-up. Dr. Vaelith is already asking questions."

The door thudded again, faster and sharper. Nyx's heart kicked inside her chest, but her brain was foggy and her body didn't move. Her finger twitched feebly against the edge of the blanket; she jerked as hard as she could and the world tilted violently. A sharp pain slammed through her skull and the blanket tumbled on top of her partially.

She heard the door hiss open and her stomach dropped.

"Nyx—" Darius strode into the entryway, eyes glowing brightly. He took one look at her and stopped cold. "What the hell is wrong with you?"

Nyx tried to focus, but her thoughts swam. She could barely even think right now, but this was definitely not good. "I'm... fine," she whispered hoarsely.

Darius crossed the room and crouched beside her, lifting her onto the bed and covering her properly. "You're not fine," he growled. "I'm going to get the medics and Dr. Vaelith. She'll be able to—"

Shadows of Titan

“No.” Her voice was shrill and cracked. She grabbed his wrist with both hands, clumsy and trembling. “Don’t tell her. Please. I’m begging you. I just need sleep.”

Darius froze. Her fingers barely curled around his wrist, but it stopped him more effectively than a wall. Her eyes locked onto his, panicking, pleading.

She could see the war raging inside him, his jaw clenched. “Nyx,” he said carefully, “if something’s wrong—”

“Nothing is wrong. I just need sleep,” she whispered.

Darius exhaled hard and ran a hand through his already tousled hair. His molten veins dulled to a flicker.

“Fine,” he muttered. “But I’ll be back. And when I come back, you’d better be up and talking. I’m not covering for you twice.”

She let go of his wrist and nodded faintly. He stared at her a beat longer. She forced her face to look more alive, flashing her teeth in a half-smile.

“I mean it, Nyx,” he said, his voice stern. “This isn’t normal. I don’t care how strong you are.”

She didn’t reply. He turned sharply and walked out, the door hissing closed behind him. Nyx dropped back against the bed, relieved, her mind already fogging over. She would get up, she thought, and she would find something or someone somewhere.

Sleep caught her in the space between thoughts, the silence pulling her under like a frozen tidal wave.

Her eyes fluttered in the dark silence. For a moment, Nyx didn’t move. She just stared at the wall opposite her bed, unsure of what had stirred her. As she reached for her comtech on the

Shadows of Titan

side table, her hunger came flooding back. It was the second hour. Next cycle. She had slept through the whole day into the next morning.

She pushed herself up by instinct and instantly regretted it. Her limbs were jelly and she felt like her head was stuffed with sand. Her balance shifted, and she looked around wildly for something to support herself.

Her hand landed on the desk chair. It creaked as she leaned into it. Her knees almost buckled as she pulled herself up, and for a second she thought she would pass out.

Step by step she made her way to the shower stall. The water pulsed from the nozzle at her command. Hot, clean, and utterly tasteless. She let it soak into her skin, saturating her pores, her scalp, her throat. It didn't feel filling, not like real feeding, but it brought a dull steadiness back to her limbs.

She stood like that until she lost track of time. When she had had enough, she wrapped herself in a thermal towel and collapsed back into bed. Her muscles still felt like sandbags and her mind was fuzzy. But there was no hum in her ears as her eyes slid closed again.

This time, when she woke, it was to a warm hand resting gently on her shoulder.

Her eyes flew open.

Darius was crouched beside the bed.

"I knocked," he said quietly, eyes scanning her face with an intensity that made her chest tighten. "You didn't answer."

His voice held an edge of worry. None of the frustration from yesterday. She wondered what had changed. She cleared her throat and forced herself into a sitting position. "It's my mutation," she said finally, her voice barely above a whisper. "Using it... drains me. I can't just pull energy from nowhere."

Shadows of Titan

Darius frowned, the molten glow of his veins dimming slightly as his brows knit together. “What kind of energy?” he asked. “I don’t get it. The mess hall doesn’t stock what you need?”

“No.” Nyx shook her head, the motion slight, but it felt like her head was cracking open. “It’s not food. I need energy. Real energy. Life-energy. Something my mutation can absorb.”

His eyes sharpened instantly. “Absorb? **How?**”

She didn’t answer right away; the right words were hard to find as her fingers weakly played with her blanket. “Inanimate things, like food, don’t work,” she murmured at last. “They give me almost nothing. Like sipping air. It barely staves off the inevitable.”

She lifted her hand again and let it fall with a hollow thump between them. “Trust me, I’ve tried eating. It just doesn’t work. No matter how much I eat.”

Darius’s expression had shifted from confusion into something heavier. His molten veins flared brighter when he was thinking, she noticed.

“So, what do you use?” he asked, his voice a quiet rumble. “Where do you get this life-energy from?”

She didn’t look at him. Just stared at the polished flooring like it could swallow her whole. “Dregs,” she said at last. The word hung in the air like acid. “Dregs who were spun out. I didn’t need much. Not before. I wasn’t using my energy like this... not constantly.”

His posture shifted and she felt the judgement in it. “You’ve been feeding off of people?” he asked incredulously.

“It’s not like they were innocent,” she snapped faster than she meant to. Her voice sounded thin even to her. “They were already flashcracked. They would’ve levelled sectors, hurt others, not just themselves if I hadn’t...”

Shadows of Titan

She trailed off, trying to find the right words. “It doesn't hurt them,” she finally whispered, the lie bitter on her tongue.

Darius let out a long exhale. His hand raked across his jaw and his gaze was distant. “And now you are using your powers a lot. Vreck.”

“Training, patrolling, rescues. I don’t have anyone I can take from,” she finished with a sigh.

Darius didn’t say anything for a while, but she could see the wheels turning behind his eyes. Weighing things. Calculating.

Then he stood, stepped away from her bed, paced once, twice, then turned back.

“Do you have to kill the Dregs, what are the side effects?” he asked. “Or can you just take the energy? Does that deplete them permanently? Do you know?”

Nyx blinked at the barrage of questions. “Just the energy. I think. I honestly have only done it that way a few times, but they said they were fine,” she said honestly.

He nodded once, slowly. “So...” he said, leaning on the edge of her desk, facing her. “Why not take mine?”

Her head jerked slightly. “What?”

“We are partners, after all,” he said, shrugging as though it were obvious. “I’ve got plenty of energy to spare. My mutation regularly goes overboard. You’re crashing. Use mine.”

Her breath caught slightly. “I...”

He stepped closer, his voice low and even. “I mean it.”

“You don’t understand,” she said, louder this time. Her body straightened with the effort. “I don’t know exactly what will happen. I’ve never done it with someone like you. I don’t even know what kind of energy you have. If it’s too volatile or I take too much.”

Shadows of Titan

Darius raised a brow, but didn't interrupt.

"I've already..." She stopped, swallowing hard. Images of Vexal's broken body flashed through her mind.

He didn't flinch or argue. He just looked at her, his molten stare soft. "You're scared."

She didn't answer. She didn't have to; her hands were trembling in her lap. "If I take too much," she whispered, "I don't know what happens. I just... I don't know."

Her shoulders slumped forward under the weight of it all.

Darius exhaled hard, dragging a hand through his hair as he rocked back on his heels. His jaw flexed, the tension loud enough to almost hear.

"This isn't sustainable, Nyx," he said finally, his voice low but not harsh. "You know that."

"I know," she said, her voice small. "I promise I'll figure this out. I just need more time."

He didn't argue, but he didn't agree, either. The silence between them stretched for a long moment. Then, without a word, he stood, his molten energy dimming beneath his skin, cooling as he turned toward the door.

"Darius?" Nyx called. He paused, his hand hovering over the panel. "Thank you."

He gave a soft nod, then he was gone, the door sealing behind him with a hiss, leaving her alone in the dim, quiet space.

Time, she thought bitterly, turning her face toward the wall.

Time isn't on my side.

Chapter 16

The sun poured molten gold across the Apex Corps compound, glinting off the metal spires and the glass-panelled corridors like everything was perfect, ordered, and clean. But to Darius, everything felt dim. He walked his patrol route in silence, boots echoing against the steel beneath him, eyes scanning the skyline. He couldn't stop thinking about her. Nyx, curled up on her bed, her body shaking, looking barely alive.

"Damn it," he muttered, slamming a dented panel onto the transport cart harder than necessary. His patrol partner, a new recruit with a magnetic mutation, flinched but didn't speak.

Smart.

Shadows of Titan

Why didn't I tell Vaelith? The question gnawed at him. The doctor would've run a dozen diagnostics by now. Isolated Nyx. Monitored her vitals. Controlled the situation.

Nyx wasn't a situation. She was terrified, that much was for sure. And if Vaelith saw that crack at her Tier, she'd move to containment. And King? He'd pounce on it ruthlessly. He would never hear the end of it. They'd use her, strip her down to her energy, and lock her away behind AAN protocols and golden doors.

By the time the sun dipped beneath the skyline and the lights of Helion Prime flickered like stars in the night, Darius had made his decision.

The dorm was too quiet. His glow dimly lit up the halls as he moved, tension coiling in his shoulders. He wasn't stealthy by nature, but tonight he didn't make a sound. Something felt wrong.

His boots stopped in front of her door. The air here was still, almost dead. He pressed to the frame. Cold. Hadn't been open in hours.

"Nyx," he called, knocking firmly. "You missed roll call and dinner. I'm going to have to speak to Dr. Vaelith."

Nothing. His chest tightened. "Nyx?"

Still no answer. His fingers danced across the access panel. The override code was confirmed in milliseconds. The door hissed open and his breath stopped.

She was sprawled across her bed like a broken doll, her dark towel tangled around her frame, her limbs too still, like there was nothing left in her body. Her skin had gone translucent, veins glowing faint and blue like cracks in obsidian. Her silver eyes were barely open, the light in them flickering like a dying ember.

Shadows of Titan

“Nyx.” His voice cracked as he dropped to his knees beside her bed. “Hey... hey... stay with me, c’mon.” His hands hovered over her body, uncertain where to touch without making things worse. He settled for her shoulder.

Her body shuddered, then slowly, her eyes tracked to his, her lips parting. “Darius...” It was nothing more than air.

He leaned in, his body flaring with panic. “What do I do? Tell me what to do?”

She couldn’t answer. Just looked at him, her eyes slowly dimming.

“No. No, no, no. You said you needed energy. You either take it from me or I’m calling the medics **now!**” he growled.

Her eyes widened, a flicker of alarm bleeding into them. “No...” she rasped.

“You won’t hurt me,” he said again. “Take what you need. Just tell me what to do.” He leaned closer, cupping her face with his hands.

Her breath hitched. Tears slipped from her dull silver eyes, streaking down her ebony cheeks like liquid starlight. “You don’t understand...” she whispered. “If it’s too much... I don’t know what will happen.”

“I don’t care.” His thumb traced her cheek. “You trust me, don’t you?”

The tears came faster now, silent and raw.

“Yes,” she whispered.

“Then let me help you.” His voice softened. “Please. Take it.”

She hesitated for a moment; her hand hovered between them, shaking like she couldn’t decide whether to reach or run. Then she moved, slow and careful, until her palm pressed against his chest, just above his heart.

Shadows of Titan

His energy welcomed her. And as she began to draw energy from him, he felt it immediately. Like molten lava poured into the hollow spaces he didn't even know he was carrying. This wasn't taking.

A low sound tore from his throat. Something warm started in his chest and surged outward like a flood. The energy in his veins flared violently, casting the entire room into a roaring amber haze.

The light spilled over her like firelight, and the heat was suffocating. But she didn't flinch. Nyx started slow at first, like she didn't trust what was happening. Then she pulled harder.

Darius groaned, jaw clenched tight, every muscle in his body locking to keep from collapsing. The energy tore out of him in waves, wild and insistent. It wasn't gentle or sweet; it was raw, devouring his very soul. Her silver eyes blazed back to life, burning so bright it hurt, but he couldn't look away. She was drawing from the very core of him, but he didn't care. He wanted her to.

Her fingers curled into his chest like she was drowning and he was the only thing keeping her above water. "Darius..." Her voice cut through him.

"I've got you," he rasped, pressing his forehead to hers, their breath tangling together. "I'm not letting go. I've got you."

His energy poured into her like a flood, thickening the air between them until the heat was unbearable even to him, but he didn't care. She was glowing in his arms, the power between them intoxicating.

He wanted more. Wanted *her*.

She looked up and met his gaze fully, her eyes alight with something terrifying and beautiful.

Shadows of Titan

He felt his energy give one final surge, the room reaching what he knew was a critical heat before he pulled back. The room dimmed at once, and he sagged forward, catching himself with both hands, sweat dripping from his brow. His veins still glowed and flickered, but fainter now. Her weight was slumped against the bed, her breathing heavy but steady. The light in her eyes was still burning.

He didn't move; he couldn't just yet.

"You're **insane**," she whispered.

He gave her a half-smile, and something between a huff and a laugh escaped him.

"Yeah," he said, brushing her hair back. "But it worked, didn't it?"

Nyx didn't answer, but the concern on her face said enough. Her brows knotting together and the tremble along her lashes proved it. She reached over and pulled him down beside her. He didn't resist. He couldn't have if he had wanted to. Her touch was soft and tender; it made his chest tighten.

She shifted over him, slow and deliberate, one leg slipping over his hips as she hugged his body. Her hand pressed to his chest again, the same place she had drawn from him only seconds ago, but this time it was reversed. The power rolled back into him, slow and searing, like light travelling up his body touching every part of him.

Darius sucked in a breath as the rivers of energy connected and looped, syncing rhythms until he couldn't tell where his began and hers ended. It was synergy, but more than any feeling he had before.

His body flared, a surge of Volcanic heat tore through him, arching across his skin. He groaned, body shuddering beneath her as fire bloomed hot and boundless over his skin.

Shadows of Titan

She didn't flinch away, her silver eyes never leaving his. Her face was calm and relaxed, even though the heat between them was melting through the sheets and the bed itself.

He wrapped his arms around her without thinking, pulling her tight against his chest. She sank into him, the contact causing his energy to flare wilder.

In a final pulse of power, he felt the energy cease. The room started cooling down, the automatic thermometer going into overdrive.

She didn't move and neither did he. Her face was buried in the crook of his neck, her breath slow and even. His hand was resting on her spine, his fingertips memorising the shape of her. His heart was still racing, but the fire inside him had steadied, and the energy burned alight within him.

Darius felt the weight of the night press in and his eyes fluttered closed. The heat and energy settled to a soft pulsing ember between them as he drifted off to sleep.

Darius woke slowly, but didn't open his eyes right away. The warmth pressed against his chest felt so good and perfect. Nyx's body was tucked neatly into his arms, her breath soft against his collarbone, the steady rhythm syncing with the strong thrum of power that pulsed through his veins.

He could feel her eyes on him, watching him. "You're staring," he smirked.

There was a sharp inhale and she shifted slightly. "I'm not," Nyx mumbled with a small laugh.

Shadows of Titan

He cracked an eye open just in time to see her silver gaze dart away, but not before he caught the soft glow in her irises and the faintest hint of colour rising to her dark cheeks. Even in the pale light, her obsidian skin held the beautiful shimmer of starlight.

“You are,” he said smugly, turning his head to face her fully. He reached up and gently tapped her chin, redirecting her gaze. “But it’s fine. I am a work of art.”

That made her laugh. Sharp and sudden, not like her careful, polite giggles. She clapped a hand to her mouth like she could take it back, but he was already laughing, too.

He sat up, dragging a hand through his hair out of habit. His skin still radiated heat, but it was more contained now, steadier. They sat in the quiet for a moment before he asked, “You feel better?”

Nyx looked down at her hands and flexed them a few times. “Yeah,” she said softly. “I feel... good.”

Darius watched her a beat longer, then rose with a grunt, rolling his shoulders and stretching until he felt a crack. “Well,” he said, reaching for his discarded gear. “We'd better get out there before we miss roll call and the AAN locks us in cryo for insubordination.”

Nyx smirked faintly, but didn’t argue. He left first, the corridor still hushed in the early morning stillness. Perfect. No onlookers, so no rumours to make things more difficult. He moved fast, prepping in silence, slipping into formation at the last minute.

He felt a wave of relief wash over him to see her already standing there as he strode up. Back straight, uniform in order.

“We’re just patrolling,” he said, sliding in beside her. She gave a small nod.

Training was off the table for now. And they were going to talk about what she was, but until then he couldn’t risk another incident like that one. He shuddered slightly. He needed to talk